

We had to fight to keep the game afloat: Legends react



SHANTHA RANGASWAMY
India's first women's team captain and administrator

This is not the time to reflect on the lack of facilities during our time. This is the time to enjoy and bask in the glory of the team's success. This win is going to have a major impact on the game. Hypothetically speaking, if there are one lakh women cricketers in the country now, this World Cup win will ensure that number increases tenfold.

It will draw a lot of youth to cricket. The 1983 World Cup win

put India on the world map of cricket. Likewise, this win will catapult India into becoming one of the leading women's cricket countries in the world, and the base will get widened.

That is the biggest contribution of Harmanpreet Kaur and her team. We had to fight to keep the game afloat, and now the number of players will increase exponentially. That's the biggest gain.

SUDHA SHAH

Former India captain, coach and administrator

When Harmanpreet Kaur took that final catch, I could not control my emotions. This was something all of us had dreamed of, and when the girls finally did it, it felt as if they were living our dreams.

It should have happened much earlier because we had been improving steadily, and the facilities and support structures are much better now. But better late than never. The best part is that millions of Indians watched the game on television and cheered for the players — that in itself is a huge achievement.

We reached the ODI World Cup final in 2005 but lost to Australia, and then, in 2017, it was another heartbreak. As a former player, it is deeply satisfying to see that all our hard work and sacrifices have not gone in vain. Just as the 1983 World Cup win transformed men's cricket, hopefully, this moment will mark a similar turning point for women's cricket. But now the girls must work even harder and continue on the same path.

DIANA EDULJI

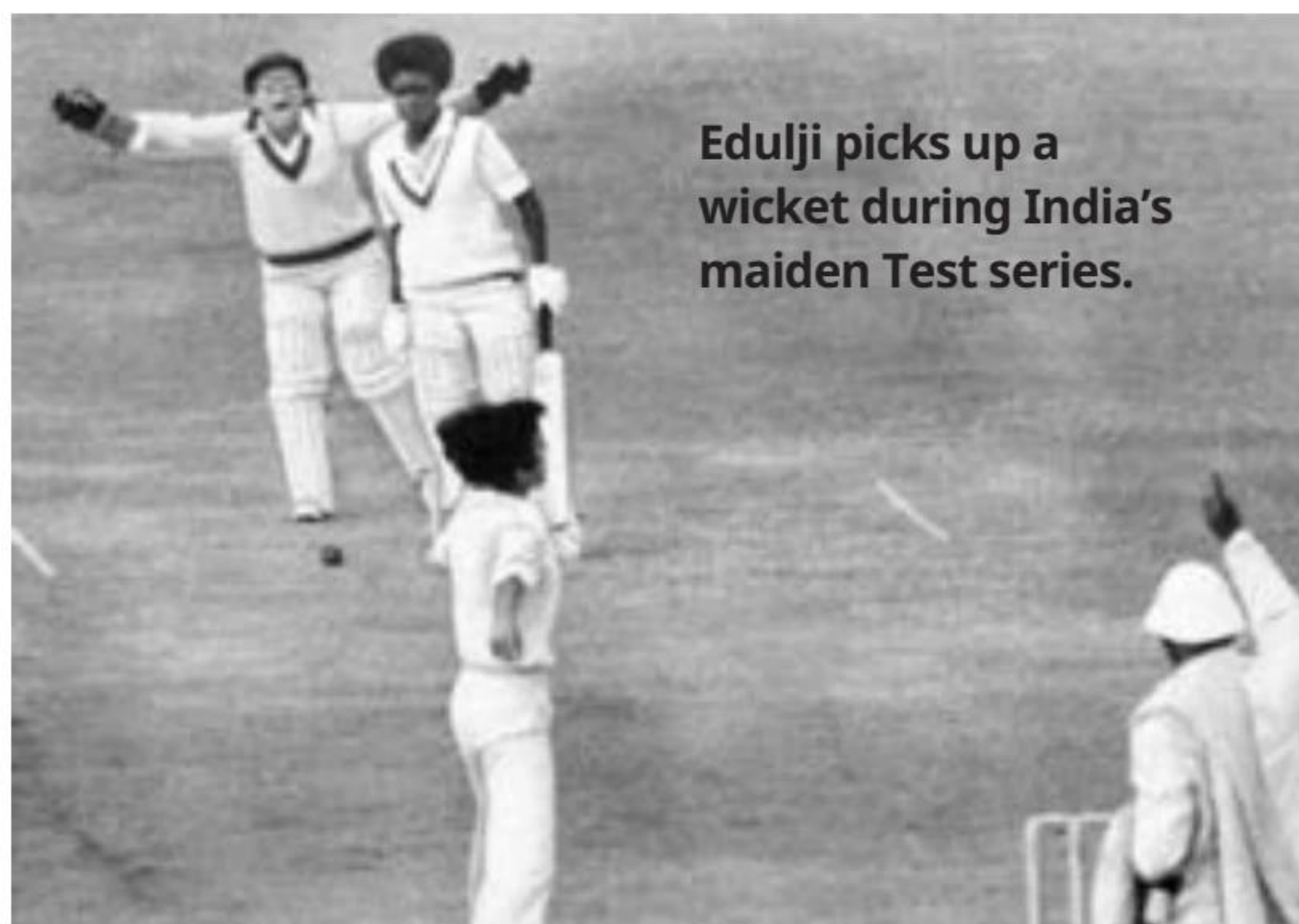
Former India captain and administrator

It has been a long 50 years for us, and this victory has truly made my day. It has made my struggle over the last five decades, as a player, an administrator, and a mentor, worth it.

All our hard work has borne fruit with this trophy. We missed it narrowly in 2017, and that was the real turning point. I wouldn't call this a 1983 moment at all; I believe it was in 2017 that everyone started taking women's cricket seriously. The key factor then was that the matches were telecast live, and that visibility drew attention.

When I was a Committee of Administrators (CoA) member, I took several steps to ensure that women cricketers, both past and present, received their due. It wasn't easy, because the BCCI had never functioned with women's cricket in mind; it was always about men's cricket. The common refrain was that women's cricket didn't generate revenue. Even so, we introduced one-time benefits for players, ensured they travelled business class, and stayed in single rooms in five-star hotels. We treated them on par with the men.

Those were the steps we took, and I believe this World Cup win will have a profound impact on young cricketers.



Edulji picks up a wicket during India's maiden Test series.

NEETU DAVID

Former India captain and erstwhile chairperson, national selection committee

For the last five decades, we have been waiting for this moment. But Harmanpreet Kaur and Amol Muzumdar ensured that our dream came true, and winning a World Cup at home is special. A lot of credit goes to the BCCI, Jay Shah bhai, who went out of his way to support women's cricket and ensured that the girls got everything. Similarly, VVS Laxman ensured that at the CoE, the players were well guided and it's a collective effort that we fulfilled our dreams.

As a player, I have witnessed several so-near-yet-so-far moments, but I am glad to have played a role this time. This team was criticised a lot, but that did not affect the senior players as they took things in their stride, motivated the youngsters and got the best out of them. This certainly will be a defining moment for women's cricket in India.